As soon as I get home, the England medical team tell me that I can't be at home any more. If there's any chance of me going on tour, I have to leave immediately, with no more physical contact with anyone. I'm packing my bags in silence, suddenly ruptured from my family. I'm just going to leave quietly, not make this any worse than it needs to be. We all know that, best case scenario, I will not be back for three months now. That's going to be extended by an extra week, where I get an Airbnb on Altrincham High Street, in a small upstairs flat. I'm told, in very strict detail, not to leave the flat until I head off for the tour. I spend a week there, just watching the traffic go up and down the same high street, too disconnected from anyone, too cautious to even message and say what has happened. The only company I have is a masked visitor who comes to give me Covid tests every day and then leaves. I am negative. I can travel. But even when I do, I cannot sit with the squad. I need to be waiting in my own room, then on my own at the back of the plane for the duration of the 24 hours to Australia in complete isolation.

I test negative in Queensland but before I am able to rejoin the group, see anyone or get outside, we are all taken to quarantine for two weeks. Inside a single, windowless room, I wait. There is no exercise, no cricket, just my own time and space. By the time we start playing cricket, I have been completely alone for five weeks. The motel in Brisbane, for the first Test, is extremely isolated. There is a very highly monitored space and very little time allowed for preparation. On arrival, they have left each room big boxes as sort of isolation survival packs. They are full of biscuits and chocolates. Imagine the worst possible thing to put in your system before doing high-pressure, athletic sport. It's like Cricket Australia are trying to fatten us up with snack boxes.

The days unwind in endless cycles of *Call of Duty* and Netflix. We are let out for a couple of hours a day to practise, with limited contact. We are not allowed out for dinner, the hotel provide it laid out like a self-service buffet. When food needs to be refilled, everyone must leave the room, pull the shutters down and then wait for it to be announced on the tannoy that we can come back in. It is part prison, part *Black Mirror*, but inside an Ashes tour. It feels like it rains the entire tour.

In preparation for the first game, we cannot bowl because it is too wet. There are no indoor nets. To get miles in our legs, Phil Scott, the strength